That the dhamma being propounded must be regarded as work in progress was an idea Ashoka sent out via other parts of the message. His successors —sons, grandsons, and 'the generations coming after them till the destruction of the world'—would continue his acts of merit, for 'whosoever among them will abandon even a part of it will do an act of demerit'.[30] This warning betrays anxiety at the spectre of impermanence: guilt over his own usurpation may have been some part of the anxiety since the expectation that his successors would respect a tradition he was establishing had been diluted by his own record. Hammering home the dhamma, literally as well as metaphorically, by casting it in stone seems in part at least to have been the consequence of some nervousness over whether 'his descendants may conform to it.'[31] Stating and restating that he wanted dhamma to continue as state policy beyond his reign betrays a deep insecurity at the obvious difficulties in ensuring continuity faced by all monarchs of the time, such continuity having been violated in other respects by his own actions as a prince.

Concern over continuity through time is complemented by the interest in dissemination through space. To provide his administration and subjects with a sense of the territorial length and breadth of the empire to which they belonged, and of the larger world of rulers that formed part of his sphere of interaction, will have been an important motive for the massive coverage Ashoka wanted. This was, in a sense, a message given out via the spread of a message—the sense being given of a huge empire. A panoramic vista of states in every direction beyond it is ultimately also a technique for communicating imperial strength, and obliquely thereby the power of the message and the requirements being spelt out. At Erragudi, for instance, people were likely to have known of political entities beyond their borders in the South, such as the Cholas and the Cheras. These realms had cultural and commercial contacts with North India from at least the fifth century BCE.[32] Kodumanal, presently in the Erode district of Tamil Nadu, was a